

Inspection of North Lincolnshire local authority children's services

Inspection dates: 16 to 20 March 2026

Lead inspector: Rachel Griffiths, His Majesty's Inspector

Judgement	Grade
The impact of leaders on social work practice with children and families	Outstanding
The experiences and progress of children who need help and protection	Outstanding
The experiences and progress of children in care	Outstanding
The experiences and progress of care leavers	Good
Overall effectiveness	Outstanding

Since the previous inspection in 2022, senior leaders have sustained strong performance and further strengthened practice, delivering clear and positive impact for children, young people and families. Inspirational senior leaders, exceptional managers and staff, and robust political and corporate backing have driven continuous improvement.

The North Lincolnshire 'one family' approach is deeply embedded and delivers consistently high-quality practice for children and young people. A vast array of well-thought-out support, provided by practitioners from family hubs, is successfully helping families and improving children's experiences. Child protection and child in need work is excellent. Permanence practice and the housing offer for care leavers remain standout strengths. Leaders have a precise understanding of the service's strengths and challenges, including workforce stability and sufficiency.

What needs to improve?¹

- The consistency of approach in respect of the lifelong offer for care leavers who are in custody when they reach 21. (outcome 4, national framework)

The experiences and progress of children who need help and protection: outstanding

1. Children and families benefit from a wide range of services, including a new digital offer, group sessions, and one-to-one specialist support from skilled multi-agency practitioners. Children and families receive timely, relationship-based support through the authority's 'one family approach'. Feedback from families who use the family hubs is excellent, demonstrating how welcoming hubs are, making a positive difference to children's lives.
2. Responses to contacts in the integrated multi-agency partnership (IMAP) are mostly prompt and proportionate. Social workers seek children's ethnicity and nationality at the earliest opportunity to help inform next steps. Effective multi-agency information-sharing by a range of partners informs what actions need to be taken to safeguard and support children. There is robust management oversight in the IMAP at every decision-making point. A clear rationale for the decision made alongside initial safety planning is helping to keep children safer at the earliest opportunity. It is also enabling children and families to receive the right support from the right service, at the right time.
3. When children need help and support out of office hours, they receive a highly effective and proportionate response. The availability of the 'one family hub out of hours' and a dedicated 24/7 out-of-hours telephone line specifically for care leavers are valuable additions to the out-of-hours service that make a positive difference. They enable children and young people to receive appropriate levels of support when they are in a crisis, or when their welfare requires additional help or monitoring to keep them safe.
4. When children are identified in the IMAP as being at risk of significant harm, promptly convened, well-attended strategy meetings enable effective multi-agency information-sharing. This leads to well-considered decisions and actions to better safeguard children. Social workers undertake comprehensive child protection enquiries, which include interim safety planning to help ensure children's safety. Initial child protection conferences result in effective multi-agency planning to help reduce risks for children.
5. For children who need statutory help, including disabled children and unborn babies, social workers undertake high-quality assessments of children's needs.

¹ The areas for improvement have been cross-referenced with the outcomes, enablers or principles in the [Children's Social Care: National Framework](#). This statutory guidance sets out the purpose, principles for practice and expected outcomes of children's social care.

These fully consider children's and parents' history, their unique characteristics, and the views of children, parents (including non-resident parents), the wider family network, and the views of professionals involved with each child. Assessments of children's needs are very analytical. They seek to understand any underlying issues and result in plans that are designed to help families make lasting changes.

6. Using a relational and trauma-informed approach, social workers are skilled at building positive relationships with children. Social workers communicate with children in ways that reflect their ages and preferred communication methods. As a result, children can share their worries and aspirations. Social workers visit children regularly, and through creative, direct work they get a thorough understanding of what children are experiencing. This contributes to effective planning.
7. Children subject to child in need and child protection plans, including disabled children, benefit from highly effective multidisciplinary interventions, which help to improve their safety and experiences. Working alongside children's social workers, specialist domestic abuse workers, family support workers and dedicated health professionals help parents to address underlying issues that have been affecting their family, through one-to-one and group support. Additionally, wider family networks are fully involved in the formulation of children's plans.
8. When child in need or child protection planning does not reduce risk, or risks escalate, children enter the pre-proceedings stage of the Public Law Outline without delay. Work within this framework is comprehensive, providing parents with opportunities to make changes within their child's time frame. For many children, this results in their experiences improving and them being able to safely remain in their parents' care. For those children where change is not achieved, court proceedings follow in a timely way.
9. Children who go missing from home, or who are at risk of exploitation, receive excellent support from specialist workers in the child exploitation intervention team (CEIT) and workers within the advocacy service. This support is helping to manage and significantly reduce risks for many children. Through high-quality return home interviews, professionals seek to understand the reasons for children going missing and inform planning to prevent further incidents and keep children safer.
10. The local authority designated officer service is effective, ensuring a timely and proportionate response to allegations about individuals who work with children.
11. Recently strengthened practices with children who are privately fostered mean that social workers assess children's needs and those caring for them in a timely way. Regular visiting and monitoring post-assessment results in assurances that privately fostered children are being safeguarded and suitably cared for.

12. Children aged 16 and 17 who present as homeless receive prompt and appropriate support. For some children, because of the support provided, family relationships improve, meaning they can safely remain at home. For those who cannot remain at home, an advocacy offer helps children to sensitively understand their rights and entitlements and whether they want to enter into care.
13. A dedicated team of young carer outreach workers thoroughly assesses the needs of young carers. Plans for young carers involve the multi-agency team around them working together to alleviate their caring responsibilities. Young carers are provided with opportunities to have fun outside their caring role via group activities. They also benefit from bespoke one-to-one emotional support. This is making a positive difference to their lives.
14. Case supervision and management oversight of practice across help and protection services is consistently robust and effective. Practitioners are supported to think creatively and be professionally curious so that their practice consistently meets the needs of children and their families.
15. Children who are educated at home are supported through strong cross-agency work that identifies needs early and ensures that families can access appropriate help. The new elective home educated hub at the local sixth-form college illustrates how well the local authority coordinates its responsibilities and works collaboratively with children and their families to provide guidance and support.
16. Effective action has led to a significant reduction in the proportion of children who are missing education. Leaders demonstrate and exemplify the rapidity of their actions to act on referrals for children who are missing education. They engage effectively with relevant internal teams and external agencies to make the necessary checks. These processes are prompt. Where pupils are not in full-time education, the local authority sources appropriate provision to give children the opportunity to engage in meaningful learning and also to promote wider opportunities, including talents and interests.

The experiences and progress of children in care: outstanding

17. Children only come into care when their safety or welfare requires it. Decisions are rooted in what will best safeguard the child and support them. When children cannot remain safe at home, they move to homes that meet their needs, where they can feel secure, build trusting relationships and thrive.
18. By working closely with children's wider family networks, social workers actively seek potential options that will enable children to remain safely within their wider family network. Assessments of kinship carers are comprehensive and growing numbers of children achieve stability and permanence by living within their kinship network.

19. Social workers and managers start permanence planning whenever possible before children enter care. This reflects how deeply embedded permanence thinking is in everyday practice. They consistently explore family options and plan concurrently until children achieve their permanent home. The Children and Family Court Advisory and Support Service (Cafcass) and the designated family judge were highly complimentary about the quality and impact of court work undertaken in North Lincolnshire, resulting in children's futures being resolved without unnecessary delay.
20. Most children live in stable, in-house foster homes within North Lincolnshire, where their needs are met to a very high standard. Foster carers benefit from an excellent training offer, with a strong emphasis on therapeutic parenting approaches. A wide range of support and engagement opportunities for foster carers helps to build a strong sense of community. Foster carers spoken to during the inspection were very positive about their experiences throughout the preparation, assessment and in respect of ongoing support as foster carers. As a result, children are cared for by foster carers who are skilled and confident in their roles.
21. Many children achieve permanence by being permanently matched to their foster carers. This is giving children a sense of security and certainty about their future living arrangements. For children who live in children's homes, their needs are well met. Social workers regularly review whether this arrangement remains the most appropriate one for each child.
22. For other children, when family options have been exhausted, and adoption has been identified as the right plan for a child, the quality of work undertaken to progress an adoption plan is extremely strong. Careful and sensitive planning helps children to successfully make the transition into their adoptive family. Adopters spoken to during the inspection were unanimously positive about their adoption experiences, describing the service from the local authority and the regional adoption agency as 'efficient, kind, and very responsive'. Social workers are respectful and sensitive with their interactions with birth parents, and they carefully consider the most appropriate future contact arrangements. Increasing numbers of children are achieving permanence at the earliest possible point through foster to adopt placements.
23. Social workers support children who are placed with their parents through bespoke, regularly reviewed plans. Social workers seek to discharge care orders in a timely way, and when it is in a child's best interests.
24. Social workers have excellent relationships with children. They beam with pride when talking about 'their children' and actively celebrate their successes and achievements. Social workers use a wide range of helpful tools to complete purposeful direct work with children, ensuring that children understand their journey into care. High-quality life-story work routinely takes place, including with older children. Children's views remain central to planning and decision-making.

25. Through the regular review of children's plans, including those plans for disabled children, independent reviewing officers (IROs) closely monitor children's progress and adapt plans accordingly. While the quality of written care plans is variable, IROs know their children very well, they speak with parental pride about them, and they are fierce advocates for their children. IROs appropriately challenge when children's plans are not progressing as they should. Children benefit from the routine offer of independent advocates, and they are supported to attend their reviews and share their views. There are positive efforts to reunify children with their parents if it is safe to do so.
26. Social workers support children to spend time with those people who are important to them. Children having a 'You say who' list in their care plans helps them to identify and, in turn, sustain relationships and links to their identity.
27. Social workers consider children's religion, culture, protective characteristics and disabilities within their plans. Social workers understand children's unique characteristics and talents and encourage them to have fun and develop hobbies. Reviews capture what children are good at and how they should be supported to pursue different activities. The celebration of children's progress and experiences, including at an annual awards event, helps to enhance children's sense of achievement and self-esteem.
28. Children's physical and emotional health needs are well met. Children have initial health assessments promptly and these are regularly reviewed. When additional support is needed, social workers ensure that children get this, including through routine referrals for talking therapies via child and adolescent mental health services (CAMHS).
29. Children are supported to make good educational progress. The virtual school works effectively and collaboratively with a wide range of external professionals. Clear and well-considered links between these agencies ensure that children in care get the support they need to help them make educational progress. The attendance for children who have been in care for longer than 12 months compares favourably with national averages. Achievement also compares favourably with national averages, exemplifying that children make good progress from their starting points. When children might not achieve as well as they should, senior leaders and the virtual school work with educational settings to put support in place to address this. Older children benefit from various in-house opportunities such as apprenticeships and work experience opportunities within the council and some local external employers.
30. Effective direct work undertaken by social workers and specialist exploitation workers is helping to keep children at risk of exploitation safer. When children go missing, return home interviews help children and practitioners understand the reasons for them going missing and aim to reduce reoccurrences.
31. Separated migrant children receive a strong and highly responsive service. Social workers ensure that children quickly access high-quality legal advice and they are

supported to understand their rights and options. Practice is sensitive, culturally informed and explicitly tailored to each child's identity, background and experiences. Social workers help children build friendships and connect with other children so that they feel part of the community. Housing, education and pathway planning are well coordinated, giving children higher levels of safety and stability and clear routes into learning and opportunities as they begin to approach adulthood.

32. At the time of the inspection, no children were living in an unregistered children's home, an indication that the council's effective sufficiency strategy, including opening more children's homes, is having a positive impact. On the rare occasions when children had been placed in unlawful unregistered settings over the last 6 months, these were always as a last resort, for very short periods, and with enhanced oversight of children's welfare, safety and care by senior leaders.
33. A small number of older children in care aged 16 and 17 live in supported accommodation. These children receive bespoke packages of support informed by their levels of need and vulnerability. This, and robust IRO oversight of children's progress and wellbeing, helps to ensure that children are receiving the right support to enable them to have positive experiences.
34. Social workers, personal advisers (PAs), foster carers and residential workers help children to develop age-appropriate independence skills early. This is helping children prepare as they approach adulthood.

The experiences and progress of care leavers: good

35. Children in care meet their PA well before their 18th birthday, ensuring a strong and trusting relationship is already in place when they leave care. This early connection gives young people confidence, continuity, and a sense of being genuinely valued as they move into adulthood. Care leavers consistently benefit from this thoughtful approach, which helps them to feel supported and understood at a pivotal point in their lives.
36. PAs use their established relationships with care leavers to provide them with effective help and support. PAs are kind, compassionate and caring. Care leavers who spoke to inspectors were highly complimentary about their relationships with their PAs, saying that they are easy to contact and approachable. One care leaver described their PA as being 'like a mum'.
37. Overall, care leavers' pathway plans are personalised, well written and informed by care leavers' views. Most pathway plans are clear and ambitious, but a small number lack specific targets, and desired actions are not sufficiently ambitious.
38. PAs support care leavers to maintain and improve their physical and mental health. PAs provide care leavers with encouragement and assistance to attend health appointments and make referrals for specialist mental health support should they need this. A recently introduced monthly multi-agency meeting

discusses individual care leavers' needs to ensure that they are receiving the right help and support. This is having a positive impact on care leavers and, as a result, they are receiving the right help at the right time.

39. Most care leavers know their rights and entitlements as set out in the local offer, and PAs help them to access what they are entitled to. Care leavers have access to the important documents they need in adulthood. PAs support them to access their records.
40. PAs support care leavers to develop their independence skills and resilience. A local venue offers care leavers a place to socialise, get involved in workshops and cook together. Care leavers shared how they value having a space where they can meet each other and their workers.
41. PAs are alert to care leavers' vulnerabilities and risks they may face. They help care leavers to access universal and specialist support. As a result, care leavers' support networks increase and their safety is enhanced. PAs provide most care leavers who are parents with tailored, flexible and attentive support. However, for a very small number of parents whose children do not live with them, attention to their parenting role within their pathway plans is less comprehensive.
42. Care leavers are encouraged to access education, employment and training (EET), with evident success as the EET rates in North Lincolnshire compare favourably against statistical neighbours. When care leavers are not in education, employment or training, PAs, managers and leaders seek to identify the root cause of this to remove barriers to access and promote success in education, employment or training.
43. PAs support former separated migrant children who are now care leavers well. While participation in education is promoted, due to a local college only having an annual intake, there are sometimes delays in former separated migrant care leavers starting at college. In the interim, PAs ensure that care leavers have access to laptops and some online educational opportunities.
44. Most care leavers live in safe and appropriate accommodation. The council has a very strong housing offer, as well as an effective range of housing options and choice to meet care leavers' needs. A good number of care leavers also benefit from continuing to live with their former foster carers via 'staying put' arrangements. This provides care leavers with a secure base from where they can develop emotionally and practically before taking their next step in life.
45. PAs provide care leavers in custody who are under the age of 21 with consistent, thoughtful and determined support. However, when they reach 21, a very small number of care leavers in custody cease having an allocated PA. Although care leavers are made aware of how to get back in touch should they require further support, there is a lack of clarity as to whether the care leaver has been given a choice to continue to have an allocated PA while in custody.

46. Apart from the significant minority in custody, when turning 21, PAs consistently discuss with care leavers whether there is a need for them to continue to have an allocated PA. If no need is identified and care leavers agree, they cease having an allocated PA, with care leavers having the full awareness that they can return for support at any point in the future. For those care leavers who close to the service at 21, they receive annual contact as a minimum. They are reminded that they can return to the service and access further support at any time. Many care leavers over the age of 21 take up the 'lifelong' offer for specific help and support when they need it.

The impact of leaders on social work practice with children and families: outstanding

47. Since the previous inspection, a stable, insightful and highly reflective leadership team has taken up post following a seamless transition. The senior leadership team is resolutely child-focused and has a relentless drive for continuous improvement. Senior leaders are highly visible, respected and closely connected to the workforce. They have continued to innovate while strengthening and building on the strong foundations of outstanding practice established over time.

48. Senior leaders are ambitious for their children, and this ambition is shared across the workforce. Staff thrive in an environment that encourages professional curiosity, reflective thinking and confident decision-making. This culture strengthens practice, ensures that risks are understood and responded to well, and supports children and their families to receive the right help at the right time.

49. Strategic partnerships are impressive and exceptionally strong. This is exemplified by a comprehensive, impactful early help offer through multi-agency family hubs. The 'one family' approach is embedded not just across children's services but across the council. In addition, the housing offer for care leavers means that most care leavers live in accommodation that meets their needs. These multi-agency approaches are helping to transform the lives of North Lincolnshire children.

50. Corporate and political leaders share the senior leaders' aspiration to continually improve children and young people's experiences through intervening to support families at the lowest level. This is evident in the significant financial investment in the family hubs.

51. Purposeful investment is strengthening sufficiency, including the opening of new children's homes, giving children in care the chance to live closer to the people, schools and communities that matter to them. Alongside this, the council's housing strategy ensures that care leavers can access good-quality, safe and stable accommodation within their home area.

52. An effective corporate parenting board provides robust scrutiny and challenge to senior leaders on behalf of children in care and care leavers. Through regular communication with children and young people, corporate parents have a real

understanding of children and young people's successes and challenges. Leaders across the council are proud of and celebrate children and young people's achievements. They strive to achieve their strategic ambition for every child in North Lincolnshire to 'thrive in their families, achieve in education and flourish in their communities'. In the discrete areas where there are areas for improvement, such as the timely admission to college for former separated children, and the post-21 offer for care leavers in custody, leaders are focused on these areas and are taking action to address these issues.

53. A focus on participation with children, young people and their families is a real strength. Feedback from children and their families across the service is heard, understood and acted on by leaders. Participants of the 'cool kids' participation group (children subject to child in need and child protection plans), and the impressive 'get loud' (children in care and care leavers) group actively hold leaders to account and inform service development. For example, the views of children and families have been instrumental in the development of digital support for families. Children and families have also been involved in the co-production of strategies refreshed in the last 12 months.
54. Leaders have sustained the use of the fully embedded practice model in North Lincolnshire alongside clear practice standards. As a result, practice is relational, strengths-based and trauma-informed, while always holding children's safety at the forefront of thinking. A practitioner shared how such clarity gives them confidence in the work that they do.
55. An accurate self-assessment demonstrates how senior leaders know their service and the communities they serve well. Leaders have realistic priorities moving forward that seek to maintain outstanding services for children and families, including a continuing focus on staff retention and wellbeing, and a continuing focus on foster care recruitment. Leaders also have a determined focus on implementing changes in line with the Families First transformation.
56. Senior leaders have consistently embraced opportunities to reflect, learn and strengthen practice. They actively seek external scrutiny and challenge to test the quality of their work. This openness to learning, combined with a clear focus on children's lived experiences, has led to much stronger identification of risk and need, and responses that have greater clarity and purpose. This learning culture is embedded across the service. Practitioners are more confident, and managers are more curious and reflective. As a result, children are safer, their voices are heard more consistently, and their experiences drive continuous improvement across the whole system.
57. Excellent performance data and a comprehensive quality assurance framework, which includes high-quality collaborative auditing with families and practitioners, is providing leaders with a detailed line of sight to practice. Audits are providing individual practitioners with the opportunity to reflect and learn. Audits are also identifying wider organisational learning, which leaders disseminate to the workforce in several ways, including 7-minute briefings, group supervision

sessions, newsletters and training events. In North Lincolnshire, there is a genuine culture of reflection and learning.

58. The frontline management of social work practice is extremely strong. Regular individual supervision sessions and team meetings, which are valued by practitioners, provide staff with opportunities to discuss and reflect on children's experiences. This is informing practice. It is also contributing to consistently high standards of practice that are making a significantly positive difference to children's lives.
59. Staff are highly complimentary about the comprehensive training and development opportunities in North Lincolnshire. This is resulting in practitioners feeling confident and equipped to practise in a relational, kind, sensitive and trauma-informed way.
60. Leaders inspire the workforce to continually develop, nurturing talent from within, supporting progression and investing in future leaders. This can be seen at all levels of the organisation, up to and including the director of children's services.
61. As a result of a successful recruitment and retention strategy over the last 12 months, North Lincolnshire children's services has a stable, permanent workforce, with only minimal reliance on agency staff. Consequently, most children benefit from having a consistent practitioner, with whom they can share their worries and aspirations.
62. Staff morale in North Lincolnshire is high. Practitioners are extremely positive about their working conditions, the wellbeing offer, and the positive culture created by visible and approachable senior leaders. Practitioners also cite manageable caseloads, the practice model, and feeling fully supported and valued as reasons why North Lincolnshire is their choice of employer.

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